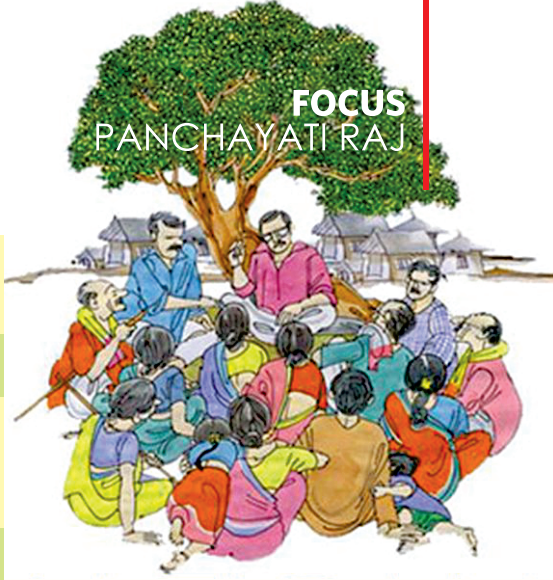


ages, the prerogative of men in politics and governance is slowly and steadily changing at the grassroots and women are at the forefront making their way in a field from which they have historically been excluded. To top it all, while the Covid crisis had disproportionate impact on women, in terms of increased vulnerability to job and income losses, and heightened burden of care work, women have shined through as being the first responders in their roles as frontline health workers, and local leaders in PRIs and Self-Help Groups.

The Benefits of RGSA Scheme: The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) has approved continuance of revamped centrally sponsored scheme of Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA) for execution during the period from April 2022 to March 2026. This measure has been undertaken to develop governance capabilities of PRIs. A total of Rs 5,911 crore has been approved with the Central share of Rs 3,700 crore and state share of Rs 2,211 crore. The purpose of RGSA is to aid around 2.78 lakh rural local bodies also consisting of traditional bodies across the country to fortify governance capabilities and improve PRIs to ensure development in villages. Furthermore, the scheme entails to enable the elected representative of PRIs to deliver on the localisation of SDGs for nine themes, – poverty-free and enhanced livelihood in villages; healthy village, child-friendly village, water sufficient village; clean and green village; self-sufficient infrastructure in village, socially secured village; village with good governance; and engendered development in village. Not to forget, the initiative will reinforce Gram Sabhas to function as an effective body that invites social participation of citizens especially the vulnerable groups. As a part of the scheme in solidifying capacity building of PRIs at national, state, and district levels, an institutional structure shall also be built with adequate human resources. All in all, the revamped initiative will be a road map to success for around 60 lakh elected representatives, functionaries, and other stakeholders of rural local bodies including traditional bodies across India.

CELEBRATION OF THE ICONIC WEEK

The Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) has recently celebrated the Iconic Week from 11th April to 17th April'2022 to commemorate Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav (AKAM) as a Jan-Utsav. The week-long commemorative events, commenced on the 11th April at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, unfolded a series of thematic conferences on the theme "Panchayaton ke Navnirman ka Sankalpotsav. The details of seven-day thematic conferences are summed up below.

- ***11th April 2022:*** **National Stakeholders Conference on Localisation of Sustainable Development Goals**
- ***12th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Good Governance**
- ***13th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Localisation of SDGs on Child Friendly Village and Engendering Development for Gender Equality in Villages**
- ***14th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Augmentation of Own Source Revenues of Rural Local Bodies**
- ***15th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Localisation of SDGs on Healthy Village and Socially Secured Village**
- ***16th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Localisation of SDGs on Water Sufficient Village and Clean and Green Village**
- ***17th April 2022:*** **National Conference on Localisation of SDGs on Poverty Free and Enhanced Livelihoods and Self-Sufficient Infrastructure in Village**

The Vice President Shri M. Venkaiah Naidu released the logo of Localisation of SDGs, Compendium of Joint Advisories to the States on Operationalisation of Localisation of SDGs and Compendium of Thematic Presentations for use by Gram Panchayats during the inaugural session. Union Minister of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj Giriraj Singh, Union Minister of Women and Child Development Smriti Zubin Irani, Union Minister of Jal Shakti Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Union Minister of State for Panchayati Raj Kapil Moreshwar Patil and Union Minister of State for Rural Development Faggan Singh Kulaste graced the occasion. State Panchayati Raj Ministers, senior officers of Panchayati Raj department of states/UTs, NIRD&PR, SIRD&PRs and elected representatives and functionaries of Panchayats were also invited to participate in the National Stakeholders Conference.

The celebration aimed at building a movement that felicitates all stakeholders to fast-track the pace of attainment of SDGs in rural India through the Panchayats on time. The Iconic Week programmes highlighted the role of Panchayats as a benchmark in achieving SDGs and taking the required steps in reinforcing community awareness and involvement.

NATIONAL PANCHAYATI RAJ DAY 2022

Since 2011-12, the MoPR has been incentivising the best performing Panchayats recommended by the state governments/UT administrators. The event is being celebrated on the 24th of April every year.

This year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Samba (Jammu and Kashmir) to address the country's Panchayats. About 8-10 departments of the government were involved in displaying new innovations and tech in rural development in this region while promoting agricultural start-ups. Also, solar plants worth Rs 2.45 crore were installed and 340 households were supplied electricity via solar power.

Panchayat Palli in Jammu was selected for the Panchayati Raj Diwas event this year and an exhibition showcasing latest innovations was put up enabling farmers, sarpanchs and village heads to advance their income and their produce.

The prominent innovations that were exhibited included geospatial technology for rural development and farmers; apps usable by farmers for weather forecast for five days; lavender cultivation famously known as purple revolution; biotechnology innovation to increase produce of apple at the same land to increase farmers' income; drone application for pesticide spray and waste treatment; shelf life of fruits to be increased through atomic radiation and much more.

The need and demand for good governance is fuelled with the rapid expansion of the economy as well as the growing awareness for proclamation of rights by the populace. PRI engagement is possibly the only existing mechanism to accomplish large-scale community participation and empower the marginalised and vulnerable, particularly women, children, and the poor. While the Centre and the state government are together implementing various development programmes, it all boils down to PRIs to have a definite mandate for realisation of the goal towards improving the quality of life in rural areas. To sum up in the words of Mahatma Gandhi, "When the Panchayat Raj is established, public opinion will do what violence can never do."